nature as, 'If you bring your fist down on it, it bursts into dozens of other tiny blobs of mercury' (Ball, 2002).

Al Qaeda suffered a continuous blow from 2004 onwards until the death of Osama bin Laden by US Seals at Abbottabad, Pakistan, in 2011. Although Osama bin Laden had informally handed over the reins of Al Qaeda to Ayman al-Zawahiri in 2006, his death in 2011 resulted in demoralisation among the ranks of Al Qaeda. Thus, drones and military actions dispersed Al Qaeda in Pakistan, but destroying it completely might take a long time. Several fighters of Al Qaeda had reportedly escaped from FATA and relocated to cities in Pakistan and as far as Somalia and Indonesia (*Dawn*, 2009).

TTP's nexus with Al Qaeda was also based on the latter's policy to appropriate local struggles and fuse them into one broad 'global jihad' (*The Guardian*, 2012). The TTP despite having regional aspirations conformed to the global vision of Al Qaeda, as it was the most vibrant and violent group operating in the area where Al Qaeda's leadership was based. This proximity was based on pragmatic needs as well. However, in fact, ideological closeness was equally important in the longer run.

There were some reports of increasing mistrust between TTP and Al Qaeda after successful drone attacks on the AQ leaders in 2012. According to a report, 'Al-Qaeda top ranks believed that it was the TTP and its commanders or people close to them who were revealing their whereabouts in Waziristan' (*The News International*, 2012). This assessment seemed quite far-fetched and weak especially when compared with developments like the formation of *shura* and killing of TTP militants along with Al Qaeda or separately. Moreover, the number of TTP leaders killed by drone attacks was more than that of Al Qaeda. The founder chief of TTP Baitullah Mehsud died in a drone attack. The reigning TTP Chief Hakimullah Mehsud was injured in a drone attack in 2011 and faced another drone attack in January 2012. Suspicions and doubts were natural because when stakes were high and killings were continual, one looked for the spies and informers. Many spies were killed by TTP for informing the Pakistani security apparatus or the Americans.

Taliban

The Taliban established a government in Afghanistan in 1996. After just five years, they were evicted from Kabul by US forces in November